BHARATVERSE

AGNI

THE THIRD FORCE

CROSSOVER: AGNI vs VAYU

CHAPTER 1

THE BRIEF

THE BRIEFING ROOM AT THE MUMBAI SECTOR OFFICE HAD NO WINDOWS AND NO NAME ON THE DOOR. MAJOR ADITYA SHEKHAWAT HAD FLOWN IN FROM POKHRAN THAT AFTERNOON ON A DIVISION TRANSPORT.

COMMANDER SHALINI BOSE SLID A TABLET ACROSS TO HIM.

Vayu.

You've seen the footage.

HE HAD. EVERYONE HAD.

BREAKING NEWS

MYSTERY MAN SAVES DOZENS IN MONSOON RESCUE

HERO OR THREAT?

A FIGURE ON A COLLAPSING WALKWAY. A WOMAN FALLING THIRTY METRES AND LANDING LIKE A FEATHER.

ADITYA HAD WATCHED IT FOUR TIMES AND FELT SOMETHING HE COULD NOT FILE UNDER DUTY. RESPECT, MAYBE. ENVY, A LITTLE.

A hundred and forty civilians in five months.

He's also an unregistered capability with no chain of command and a power set that could flatten a city block if he lost control.

We don't get to leave that out there on goodwill.

What's the mission, ma'am?

Contact and containment. Non-lethal.

No public exposure. You bring him in, he gets a seat at this table, and everyone stops guessing.

VAYU

ARJUN MEHTA

STATUS : UNREGISTERED

HEIGHT : 5'11"

AGE : 26

CAPABILITIES

- Atmospheric control
- Supersonic flight
- Pressure sense
- Vacuum strike

PSYCHOLOGICAL

Known pressure point:
Sister, Priya Mehta, missing since Aheri.
Use only if dialogue fails.

Who took her?

Not your brief.

If a girl is missing, shouldn't the Division be —

Major.

You are the best thing we have. You are also the most dangerous.

I need you to be exactly what you've always been. Can you do that?

HE THOUGHT OF THE OATH, AND OF FIFTY YEARS OF PEOPLE WHO HAD KEPT SOMETHING UNSPEAKABLE UNDER THE SAND SO THE REST OF THE COUNTRY COULD SLEEP.

HE THOUGHT: IF THIS INSTITUTION IS WRONG, THEN EVERYTHING I HAVE GIVEN IT IS WRONG.

BOTH HANDS FLAT ON THE TABLE. THE WAY HE HAD SAT IN EVERY BRIEFING SINCE HE WAS TWENTY-TWO.

Yes, ma'am.

AND SOMEWHERE ABOVE MUMBAI, BEYOND THE CLOUDS, A MAN WHO FLEW THROUGH MONSOONS HAD NO IDEA HE WAS ABOUT TO BE HUNTED.

BHARATVERSE

AGNI

THE THIRD FORCE

CROSSOVER: AGNI vs VAYU

CHAPTER 2

THE HOLE

THE GODOWN COMPLEX IN BHIWANDI WAS NINE HUNDRED THOUSIAND SQUARE FEET OF POLYESTER YARN AND STACKED CHEMICAL DRUMS, BUILT BY A MAN WHO HAD NEVER READ A FIRE CODE AND INSPECTED BY OFFICIALS WHO HAD NEVER NEEDED TO.

IT HAD BEEN BURNING FOR FORTY MINUTES WHEN ARJUN REACHED IT.

HE HAD FELT IT FROM ACROSS THE CREEK. THE WAY HE FELT ANYTHING ABOUT TO GO BADLY: A SHIFT IN THE LOAD OF THE WORLD, WRONG IN A SPECIFIC DIRECTION.

ARJUN CAME DOWN THROUGH THE SMOKE AT THE EAST GATE, AND THE SMOKE BENT AWAY FROM HIM.

ELEVEN NIGHT-SHIFT WORKERS WERE SEALED IN THE BACK BAY BEHIND A STEEL SHUTTER THAT HAD BUCKLED IN THE HEAT.

HE DID WHAT HE HAD LEARNED TO DO. HE DID NOT FIGHT THE FIRE. HE TOOK AWAY WHAT IT NEEDED.

A VACUUM STRIKE, SMALL AND EXACT. A SPHERE OF NOTHING PLACED IN THE MIDDLE OF BURNING YARN, AND THE FLAMES AT THAT POINT SIMPLY STOPPED, LIKE A HELD BREATH.

HE MOVED THROUGH THE BUILDING THAT WAY, SNUFFING AND SEALING, DRAWING A CLEAN COLUMN OF AIR BEHIND HIM FOR THE FIREFIGHTERS AT THE GATE.

HE READ THE ROOF'S LOAD THROUGH THE SOLES OF HIS FEET.

THREE OF THE MAIN TRUSSES WERE ALREADY PAST THEIR TOLERANCE. HE GAVE THE BUILDING ABOUT TWELVE MINUTES.

FORTY METRES FROM THE BACK BAY, HIS MAP DEVELOPED A HOLE.

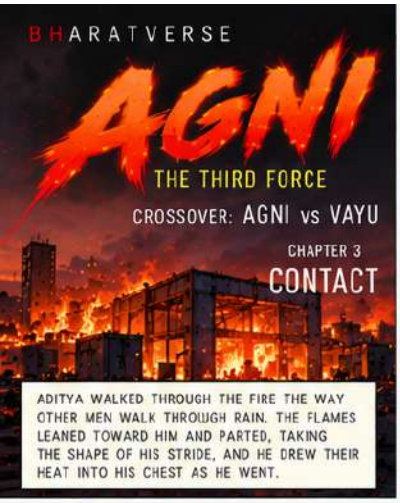
A PATCH OF THE BUILDING WHERE THE PRESSURE SIMPLY WAS NOT THERE. NO FLOW, NO GRADIENT. A DEAD SPOT IN HIS SENSE, SHAPED LIKE A MAN, AND WALKING TOWARD HIM.

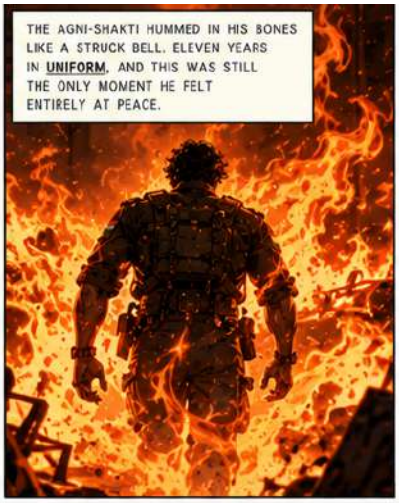
IT WAS HOT IN A WAY THAT MADE HIS SENSE SCREAM ONCE AND THEN GO QUIET, BECAUSE IT HAD NOTHING TO READ.

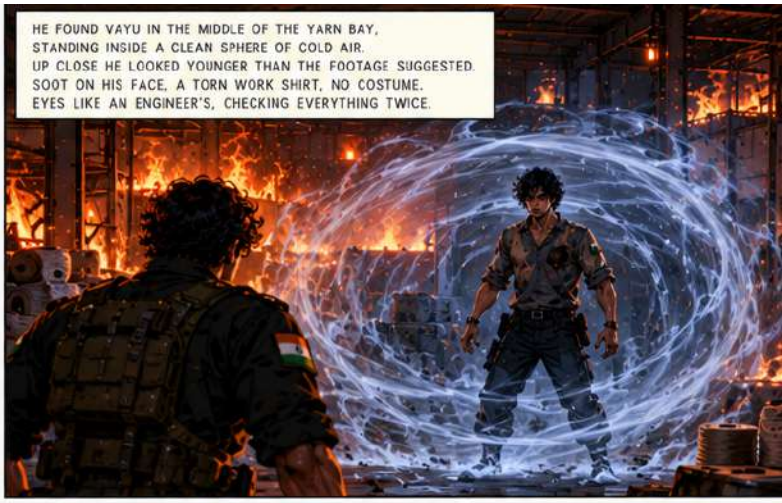
HE HAD FELT THIS BLINDNESS BEFORE, IN THE FIRST WEEK, WHEN HE'D STOOD TOO CLOSE TO A WELDING TORCH. NEVER AT THIS SCALE. NEVER WALKING.

HE THOUGHT, WITH THE CALM OF SOMEONE WHO HAS DONE THE ARITHMETIC:

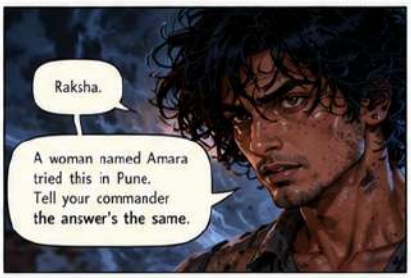
THIS IS WHAT THEY SEND **WHEN THEY STOP ASKING.**


BHARATVERSE
AGNI
THE THIRD FORCE
CROSSOVER: AGNI vs VAYU
CHAPTER 3
CONTACT
ADITYA WALKED THROUGH THE FIRE THE WAY OTHER MEN WALK THROUGH RAIN. THE FLAMES LEANED TOWARD HIM AND PARTED, TAKING THE SHAPE OF HIS STRIDE, AND HE DREW THEIR HEAT INTO HIS CHEST AS HE WENT.


THE AGNI-SHAKTI HUMMED IN HIS BONES LIKE A STRUCK BELL. ELEVEN YEARS IN UNIFORM. AND THIS WAS STILL THE ONLY MOMENT HE FELT ENTIRELY AT PEACE.


HE FOUND VAYU IN THE MIDDLE OF THE YARN BAY, STANDING INSIDE A CLEAN SPHERE OF COLD AIR. UP CLOSE HE LOOKED YOUNGER THAN THE FOOTAGE SUGGESTED. SOOT ON HIS FACE, A TORN WORK SHIRT, NO COSTUME. EYES LIKE AN ENGINEER'S, CHECKING EVERYTHING TWICE.

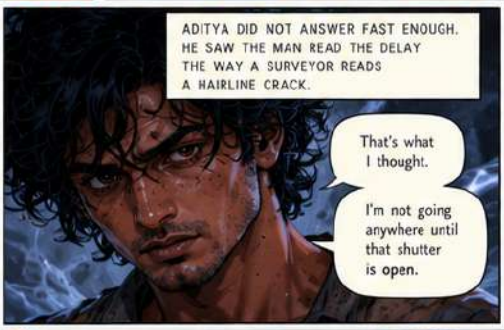

Major Aditya Shekhawat. Raksha Division. I'm authorised to offer you —


Raksha.
A woman named Amara tried this in Pune. Tell your commander the answer's the same.


There are eleven people in the back bay. I can see them. So can you.
I'm not going to fight you in front of them. Walk out with me and we do this properly.


If I leave, who opens the shutter?


I will.
And then?


ADITYA DID NOT ANSWER FAST ENOUGH. HE SAW THE MAN READ THE DELAY THE WAY A SURVEYOR READS A HAIRLINE CRACK.
That's what I thought.
I'm not going anywhere until that shutter is open.


Then I'm sorry.
Orders.


HE RAISED ONE HAND, PALM OUT, THE WAY HE HAD A THOUSAND TIMES AT CHECKPOINTS AND DOORWAYS. NOT A THREAT. A FINAL REQUEST.


VAYU MOVED FIRST.

BHARATVERSE

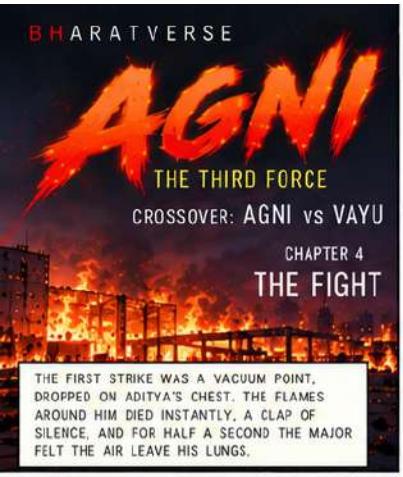
AGNI

THE THIRD FORCE

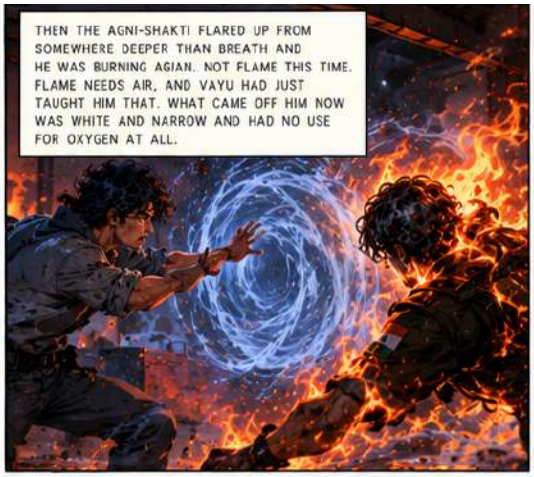
CROSSOVER: AGNI vs VAYU

CHAPTER 4

THE FIGHT



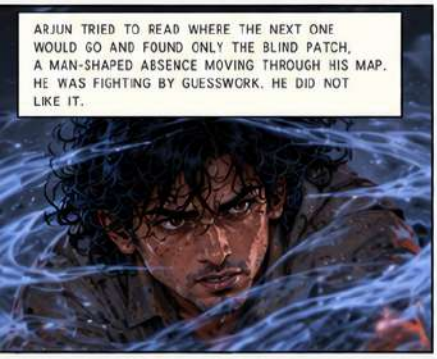
THE FIRST STRIKE WAS A VACUUM POINT, DROPPED ON ADITYA'S CHEST. THE FLAMES AROUND HIM DIED INSTANTLY, A CLAP OF SILENCE, AND FOR HALF A SECOND THE MAJOR FELT THE AIR LEAVE HIS LUNGS.



THEN THE AGNI-SHAKTI FLARED UP FROM SOMEWHERE DEEPER THAN BREATH AND HE WAS BURNING AGIAN. NOT FLAME THIS TIME. FLAME NEEDS AIR, AND VAYU HAD JUST TAUGHT HIM THAT. WHAT CAME OFF HIM NOW WAS WHITE AND NARROW AND HAD NO USE FOR OXYGEN AT ALL.



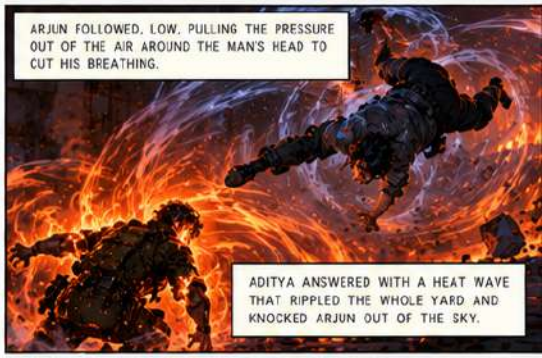
THE PLASMA LANCE WENT PAST ARJUN'S SHOULDER AND PUNCHED A HOLE THROUGH A LOADING WALL. THE EDGES RAN LIKE CANDLE WAX.



ARJUN TRIED TO READ WHERE THE NEXT ONE WOULD GO AND FOUND ONLY THE BLIND PATCH, A MAN-SHAPED ABSENCE MOVING THROUGH HIS MAP. HE WAS FIGHTING BY GUESSWORK. HE DID NOT LIKE IT.



HE THREW A COMPRESSED HAMMER OF AIR AT THE DEAD SPOT AND HEARD IT LAND. ADITYA WENT BACKWARD THROUGH TWO STACKS OF DRUMS AND A BRICK PARTITION AND INTO THE YARD, ROLLING, SMOKING, UP ON ONE KNEE.



ARJUN FOLLOWED, LOW, PULLING THE PRESSURE OUT OF THE AIR AROUND THE MAN'S HEAD TO CUT HIS BREATHING.

ADITYA ANSWERED WITH A HEAT WAVE THAT RIPPLED THE WHOLE YARD AND KNOCKED ARJUN OUT OF THE SKY.

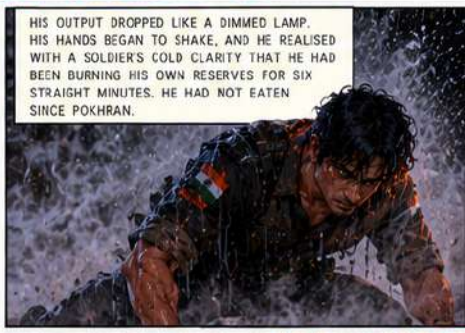


THEY WERE EVENLY MATCHED, AND BOTH OF THEM KNEW IT, AND BOTH OF THEM WERE BEING CAREFUL. THAT WAS WHAT MADE IT WORSE.

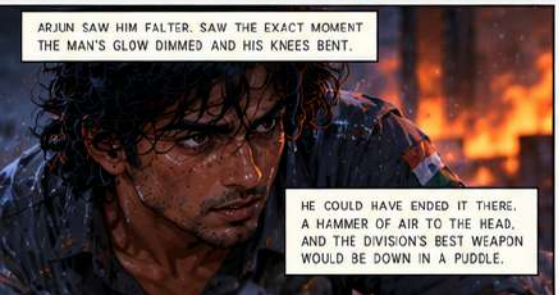
EVERY SWING WENT HIGH OR WIDE OR INTO EMPTY BRICK, BECAUSE ELEVEN PEOPLE SAT BEHIND A WALL THEY WERE BOTH TRYING NOT TO HIT.



THEN THE FIRE BRIGADE GOT A HOSE ON THE YARD. WATER HIT ADITYA ACROSS THE BACK AND THE WORLD WENT TO STEAM.



HIS OUTPUT DROPPED LIKE A DIMMED LAMP. HIS HANDS BEGAN TO SHAKE, AND HE REALISED WITH A SOLDIER'S COLD CLARITY THAT HE HAD BEEN BURNING HIS OWN RESERVES FOR SIX STRAIGHT MINUTES. HE HAD NOT EATEN SINCE POKHRAN.



ARJUN SAW HIM FALTER. SAW THE EXACT MOMENT THE MAN'S GLOW DIMMED AND HIS KNEES BENT.

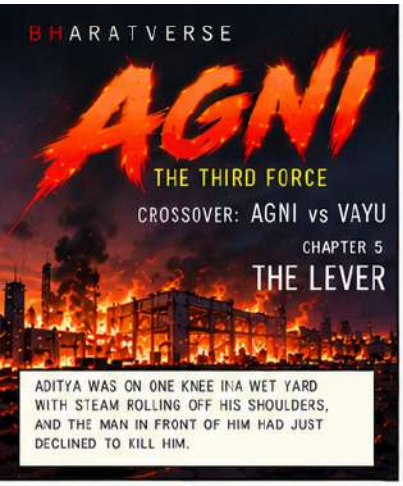
HE COULD HAVE ENDED IT THERE. A HAMMER OF AIR TO THE HEAD, AND THE DIVISION'S BEST WEAPON WOULD BE DOWN IN A PUDDLE.



HE DIDN'T.

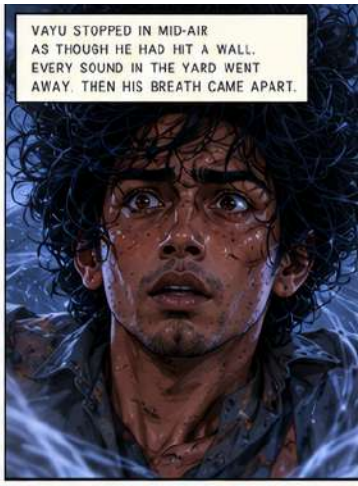


AND ADITYA, THROUGH THE STEAM, SAW THAT HE DIDN'T.


BHARATVERSE
AGNI
THE THIRD FORCE
CROSSOVER: AGNI vs VAYU
CHAPTER 5
THE LEVER
ADITYA WAS ON ONE KNEE IN A WET YARD WITH STEAM ROLLING OFF HIS SHOULDERS, AND THE MAN IN FRONT OF HIM HAD JUST DECLINED TO KILL HIM.


BOSE'S VOICE, IN HIS EAR, FLAT AND CLEAR.
Major.
Dialogue has failed. The brief has a lever. Use it.
ADITYA THOUGHT: I DON'T NEED IT. HE THOUGHT: I COULD STILL WIN THIS. HE THOUGHT OF THE OATH.


"PRIYA," HE SAID. HE SAID IT QUIETLY, ALMOST GENTLY. HE WANTED THAT TO COUNT FOR SOMETHING LATER.
Priya.

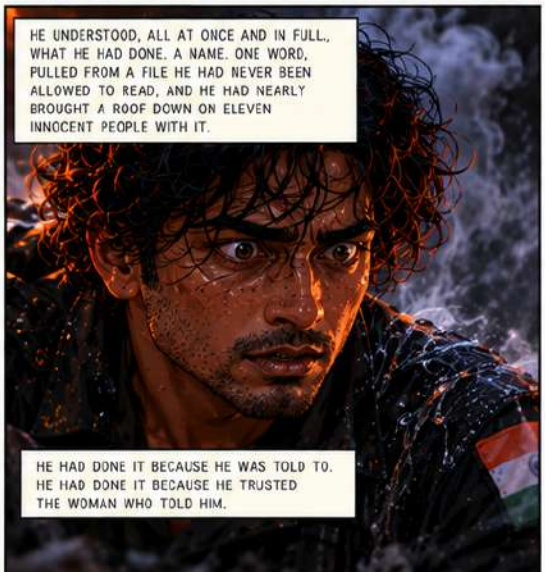

VAYU STOPPED IN MID-AIR AS THOUGH HE HAD HIT A WALL. EVERY SOUND IN THE YARD WENT AWAY. THEN HIS BREATH CAME APART.

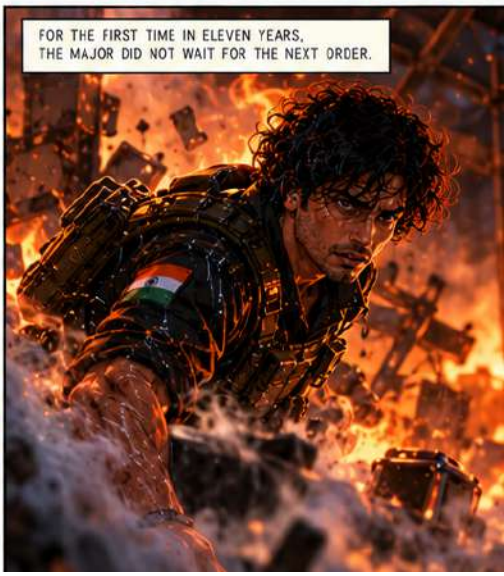

THE AIR IN THE GODOWN INVERTED. PRESSURE DROPPED, THEN SURGED, THEN DROPPED AGAIN, THE WHOLE BUILDING FLEXING IN AND OUT LIKE A LUNG.


WINDOWS BLEW OUTWARD. THE FIRE BRIGADE'S HOSE LINE WHIPPED LOOSE.


INSIDE, A STEEL TRUSS THAT HAD BEEN HANGING ON BY A THREAD BEGAN, WITH ENORMOUS SLOWNESS, TO GIVE.


AND THE SPHERE OF SILENCE THAT HAD BEEN HOLDING THE BACK BAY'S SHUTTER COOL AND INTACT COLLAPSED WITH ITS MAKER.
AAAAAH!
ADITYA HEARD ELEVEN PEOPLE BEGIN TO SCREAM.


HE UNDERSTOOD, ALL AT ONCE AND IN FULL, WHAT HE HAD DONE. A NAME. ONE WORD, PULLED FROM A FILE HE HAD NEVER BEEN ALLOWED TO READ, AND HE HAD NEARLY BROUGHT A ROOF DOWN ON ELEVEN INNOCENT PEOPLE WITH IT.
HE HAD DONE IT BECAUSE HE WAS TOLD TO. HE HAD DONE IT BECAUSE HE TRUSTED THE WOMAN WHO TOLD HIM.


FOR THE FIRST TIME IN ELEVEN YEARS, THE MAJOR DID NOT WAIT FOR THE NEXT ORDER.

BHARATVERSE

AGNI

THE THIRD FORCE

CROSSOVER: AGNI vs VAYU

CHAPTER 6

THE TURN

ADITYA HIT THE BUILDING AT A DEAD RUN, STRAIGHT THROUGH THE BURNING YARN BAY, AND DID THE ONE THING NOBODY IN THE DIVISION HAD EVER TRAINED HIM FOR. HE STOPPED BURNING. HE PULLED.

EVERY DEGREE OF HEAT IN THE FAILING TRUSS CAME OUT OF THE STEEL AND INTO HIS CHEST AT ONCE, AND THE BEAM, COOL AND STRONG AGAIN, STOPPED SAGGING BY A HAND'S WIDTH.

HE FELT THE HEAT POUR IN AND THOUGHT, DISTANTLY, THAT THIS WOULD BE EXPENSIVE.

"ARJUN," HE SAID. HE HAD NO RIGHT TO THE NAME. HE HAD READ IT IN A FILE. HE SAID IT ANYWAY.

Arjun, the shutter. I can't hold this and open it.

IT TOOK ARJUN FOUR SECONDS TO HEAR HIM. FOUR SECONDS OF A MAN PULLING HIMSELF OUT OF A DROWNING ROOM BY HIS OWN COLLAR.

THEN THE AIR IN THE BUILDING STEADIED, AND SOMETHING PRECISE AND ENORMOUS TOOK THE WEIGHT OFF THE TRUSS.

A COLUMN OF PRESSURE, BUILT BEAM BY BEAM, WITH THE CARE OF SOMEONE WHO HAD MEASURED EVERY LOAD IN HIS LIFE AND NOW MEASURED THIS ONE.

THE SHUTTER PEELED OPEN LIKE A TIN LID.

Thank you, bhaiya.

ELEVEN WORKERS RAN OUT THROUGH THE GAP. THE LAST OF THEM WAS A BOY OF NINETEEN, WHO STOPPED AT THE THRESHOLD, LOOKED BACK AT THE TWO MEN STANDING IN THE WRECK, AND SAID QUIETLY,

THEY STOOD THERE. THE TRUSS GROANED. NEITHER OF THEM HAD MUCH LEFT.

Who told you that name?

I don't know what it means.

Then ask someone who does.

AND THE WIND TOOK HIM UP THROUGH THE ROOF AND OUT INTO THE BLACK.

ADITYA SAT DOWN IN THE STEAM. SMOKE WAS STILL COMING OFF HIS HANDS, THIN AND GREY. HE THUMBED THE EARPIECE.

Ma'am. Who is Priya Mehta?

FOUR SECONDS OF STATIC. HE COUNTED THEM.

Return to base, Major.

HE LOOKED AT HIS HANDS FOR A LONG TIME.

FOR LONGER AT HIME SINCE HE WAS TWENTY-TWO, HE DID NOT STAND UP WHEN HE WAS TOLD TO.